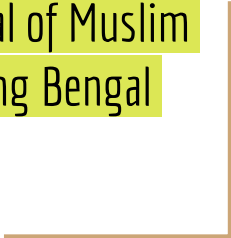




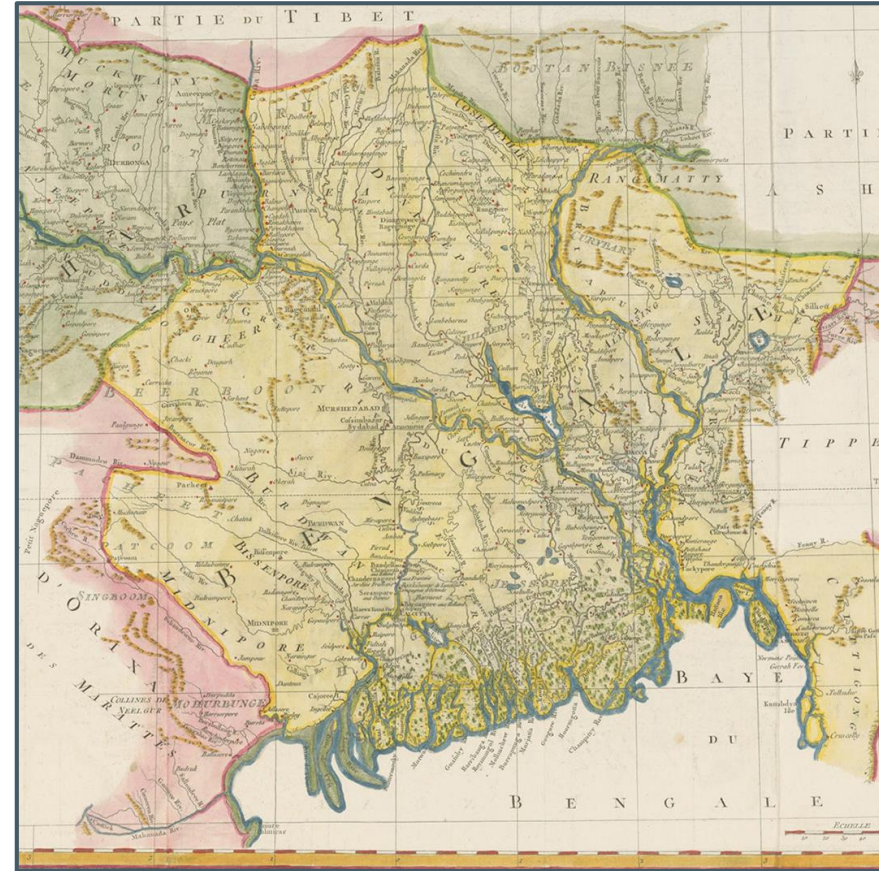
# Emergence of Bangladesh

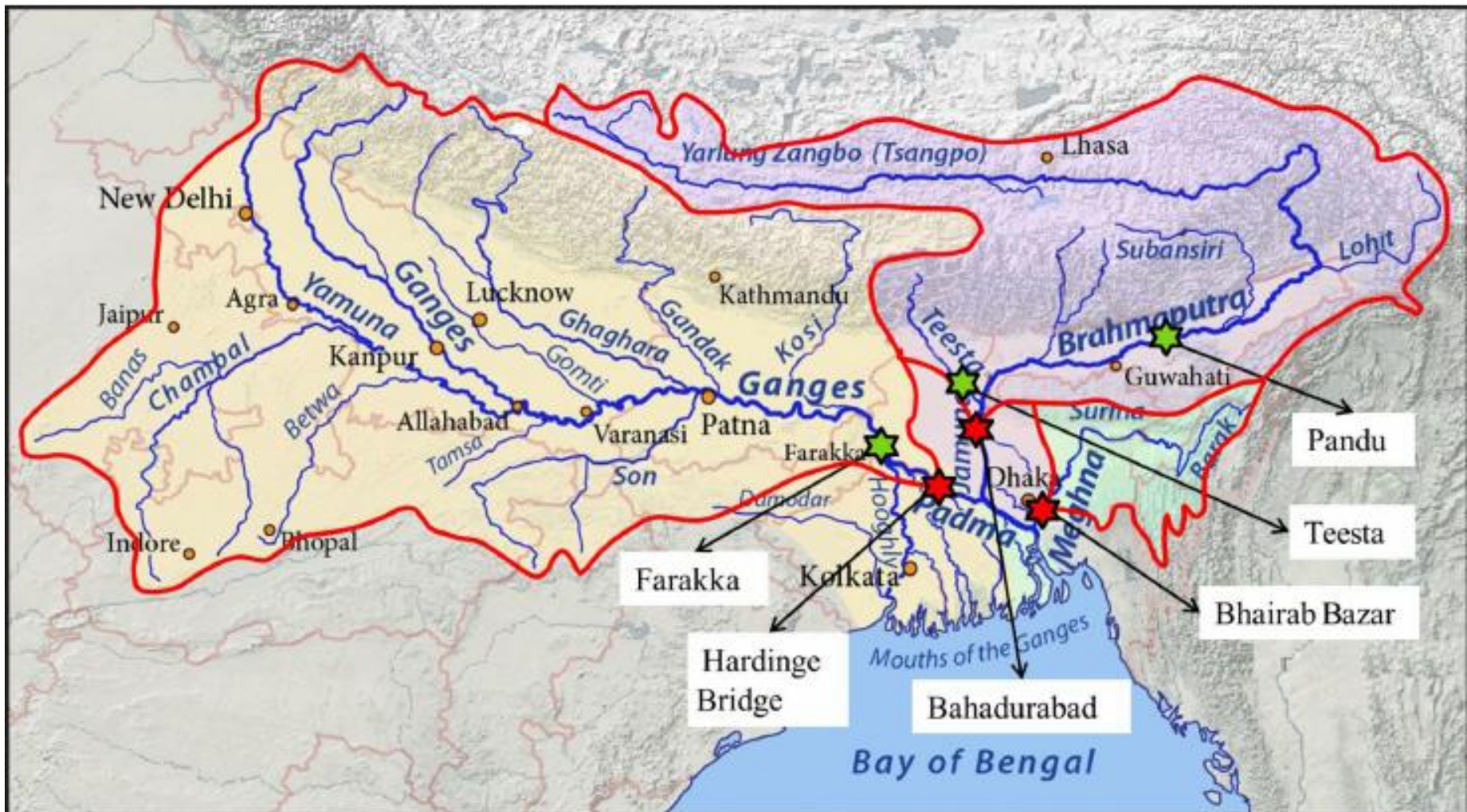
From Ancient Periods to Arrival of Muslim  
Rulers (up to 1204) : Locating Bengal



# What is 'Bengal'?

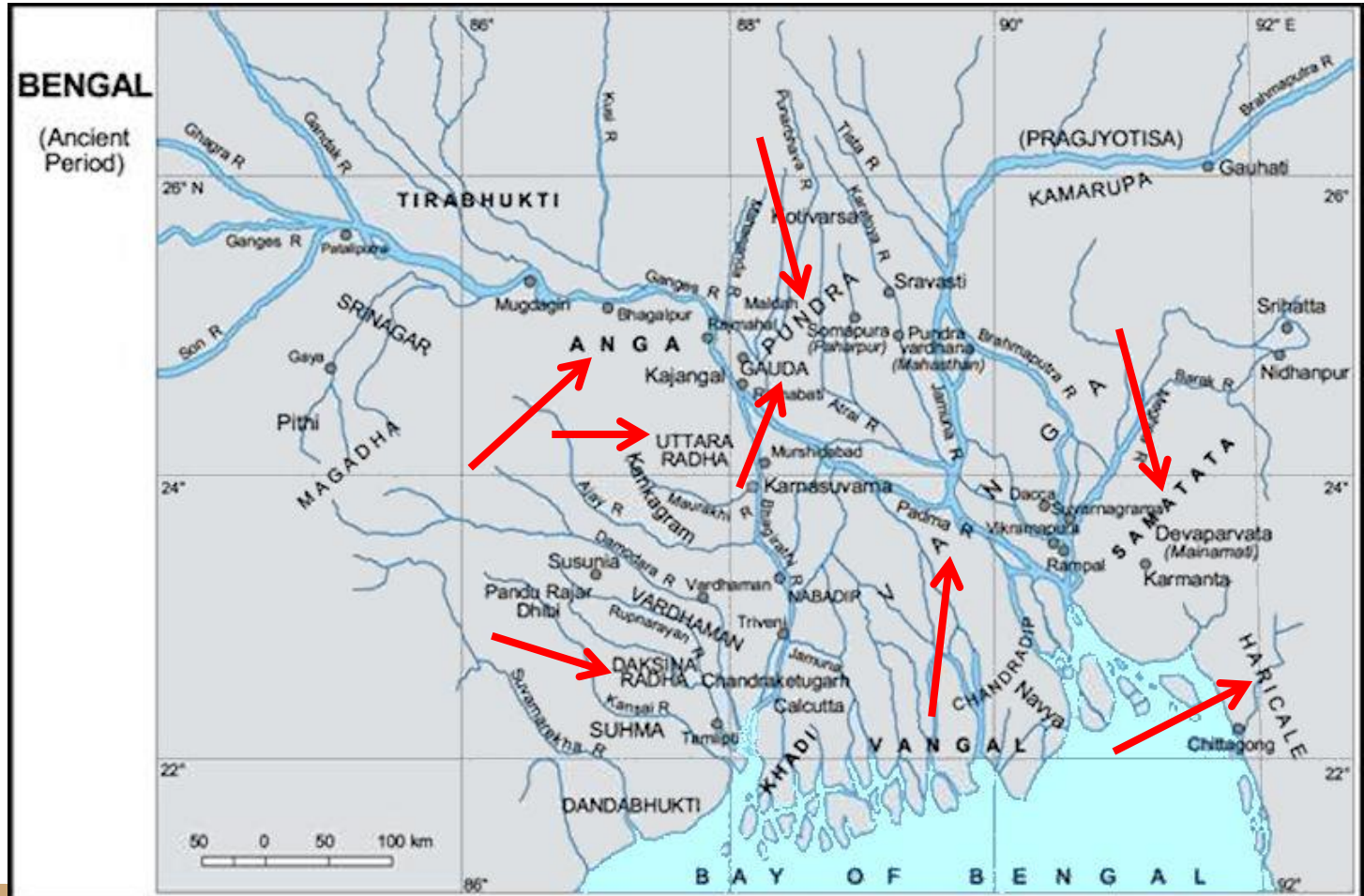
Rather than being a geographically defined region, Bengal represented a conceptual space oriented towards the lands surrounding the rivers, particularly the Ganges and Brahmaputra, that flowed through Bengal (Padma, Meghna, Jamuna) towards the Bay of Bengal







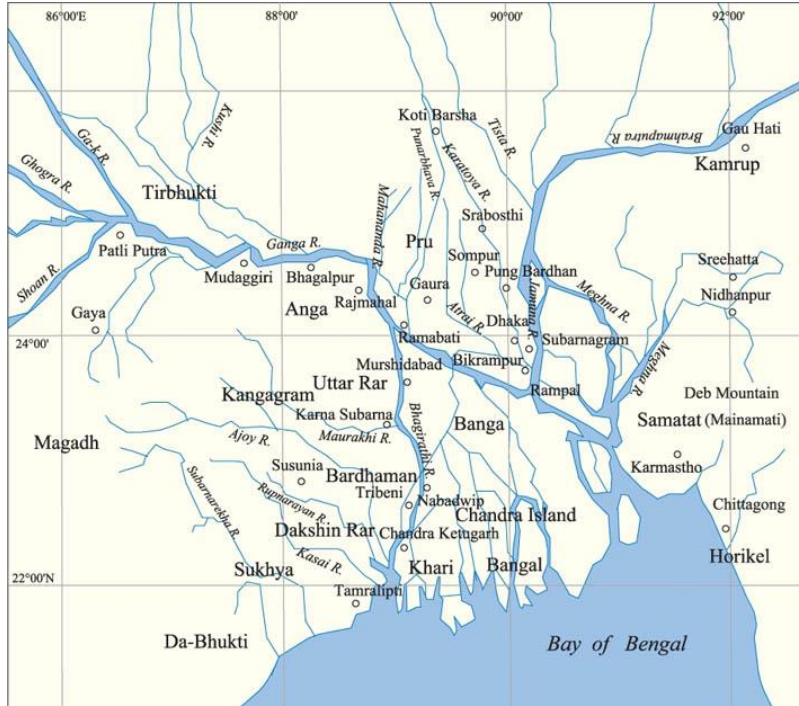
# Ancient Bengal



বাংলাদেশের  
প্রাচীন জনপদ



# Ancient Bengal



Bengal has been a place for continuous human settlement because of its **Geography and Climate**. The **rivers** are the backbone of Bengal Delta that help to yield **high crop productivity** and promoted human settlement.

A place which ensures food-security always attracts people. By 2000 BCE, **people started to settle around rivers and canals** of this delta and practiced agriculture. It was around 1000 BCE, **the growth of urban settlements** i.e. the *Mahajanapadas* are found.

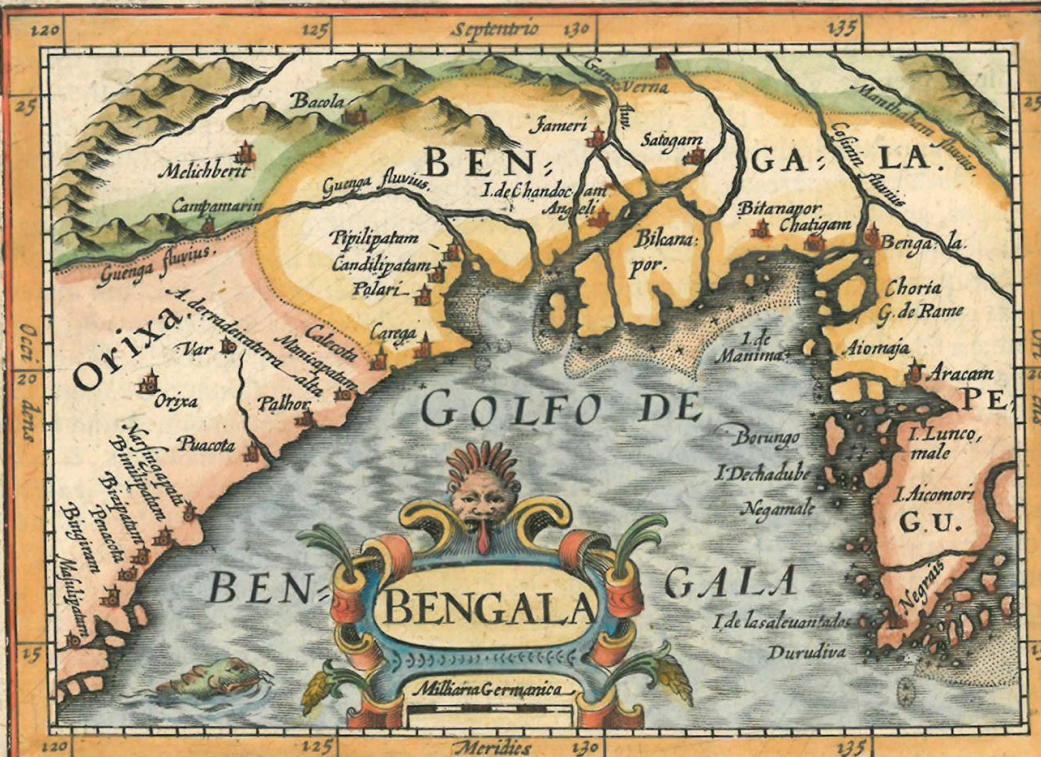
# Wari-Bateshwar

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Situated in Narsingdi, dating back to approximately 2450 years, this was the settlement of one of the ancient *Mahajanapadas*, an important trading center and a river port







First printed European map  
with Bengal as its title.

It is taken from the miniature atlas  
"Tabularum Geographicarum  
Contractarum" by the Flemish  
cartographer Petrus Betrius.



# Understanding the History of Ancient Bengal

- Racial mix
- Geography & Climate (e.g., land and rivers/canals, agriculture, food security)
- Culture (religion, language, arts, traditions/customs)
- Social and economic structure
- Political and ruling structure

# Bengal under the Mauryans

The Mauryans unified most parts of the Indian subcontinent.

During this time, the Mauryans built land trade routes which facilitated businesses/commerce and attracted people from around the continent.

Emperor Asoka played an important role by sponsoring Buddhism. He sent missionaries, bureaucrats and traders in various places with Buddhist artifacts & doctrine. This diplomatic move connected Bengal with other regions of the subcontinent and especially south-east Asia.



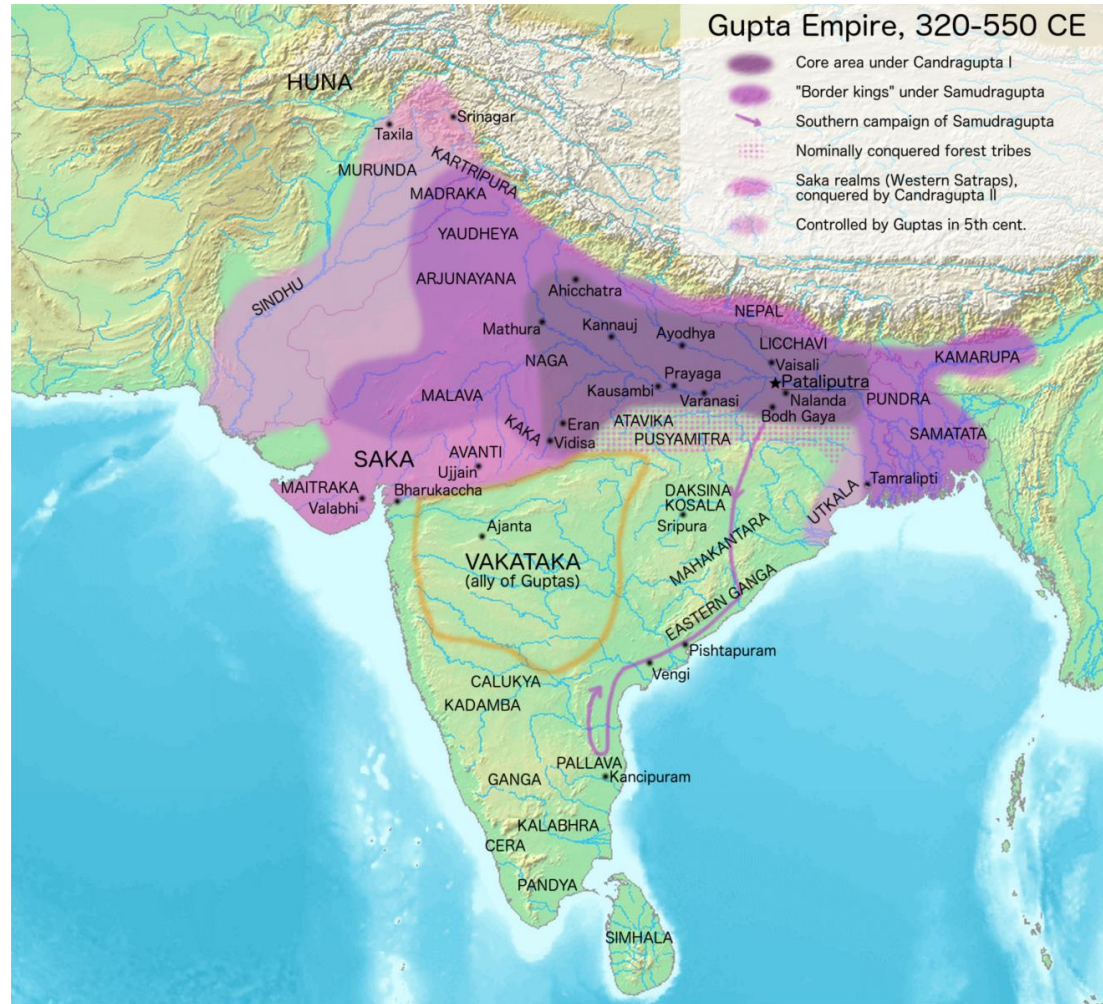
# Bengal under the Guptas

Bengal was an important province of the Guptas.

During this time, the Guptas enforced well-organized administrative system.

This era witnessed the development of arts and sculpture.

This is the second time after the Mauryans that Bengal became part of and connected to the other parts of Indian subcontinent under one administration.





# Nalanda University







# Nalanda University

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Established around 427CE  
by the Guptas.

Was one of the world's  
earliest residential  
universities

The university's library,  
"Dharma Gunj" or  
"Mountain of Truth,"  
housed millions of books  
and manuscripts.

More about the controversy surrounding Nalanda:

- *“Nalanda University: When history is not history”*

<https://dailiasianage.com/news/264922/nalanda-university-when-history-is-not-history>





# Taxila

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Taxila is considered one of the world's earliest universities, predating Nalanda and Alexandria.

The university offered a wide range of subjects, including philosophy, medicine, astronomy, grammar, and military science.

Taxila played a crucial role in the spread of Buddhism

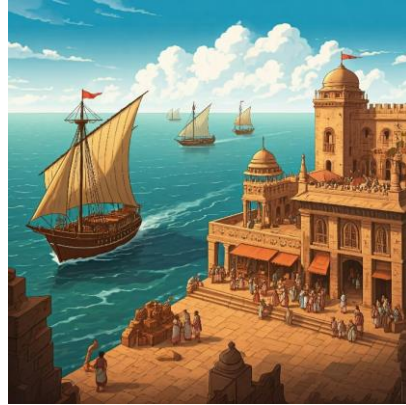
# Local Rulers from Bengal

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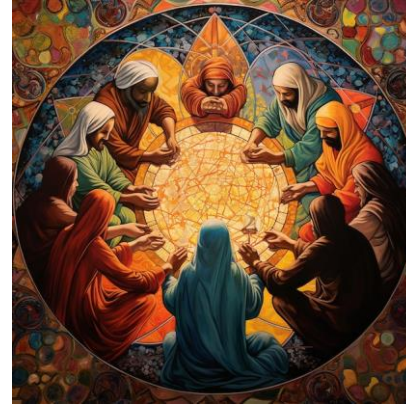
Local rulers from Bengal: the Pala, Sena, Deva, Chandra, Verman-



Sponsored learning centers



Excelled in trade



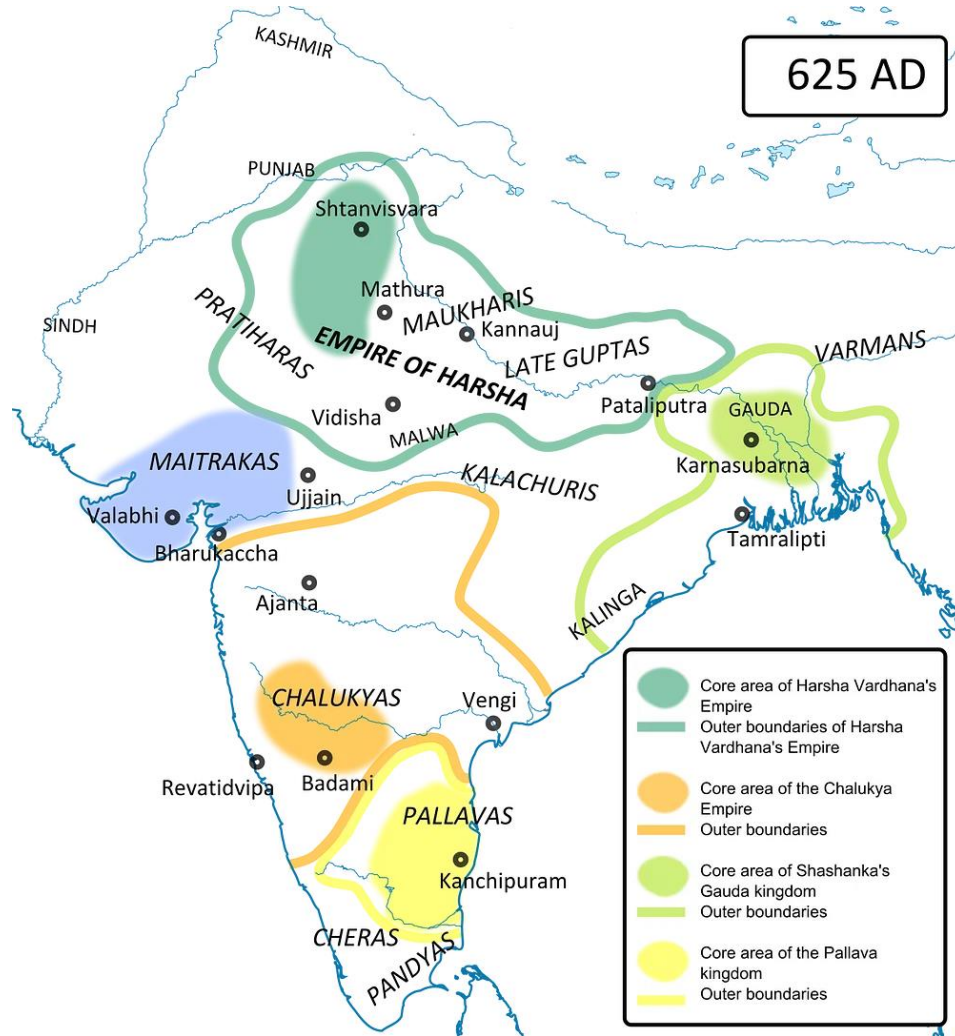
Maintained religious harmony



Instrumentalized a welcoming  
administrative system



625 AD





The Shashanka's dynasty, which ruled Bengal during 7<sup>th</sup> century AD, minted a variety of coins, primarily made of gold. However recent exploration confirmed there were silver coins too.

ROHTÁS  
SEAL of ŚAŚANGKA



**Matsya Nyaya (650-750):**

**A period of chaos, infighting and lawlessness**









# Contributions of the Rulers from Bengal

- The Palas directly sponsored several *learning institutions* such as Somapura Mahavihara, Nalanda Mahavihara and Vikramshila Mahavihara. They helped to spread Buddhism and Buddhist art in Bengal.
- During this time, *Bengali as the language of this land took the central stage*. Several Sanskrit and Pali texts were written and translated into Tibetan and Chinese.
- Admixture of Hindu and Buddhist doctrine into the social fabric of Bengal

Sompura Mahavihara established by Dharmapala in 9th century



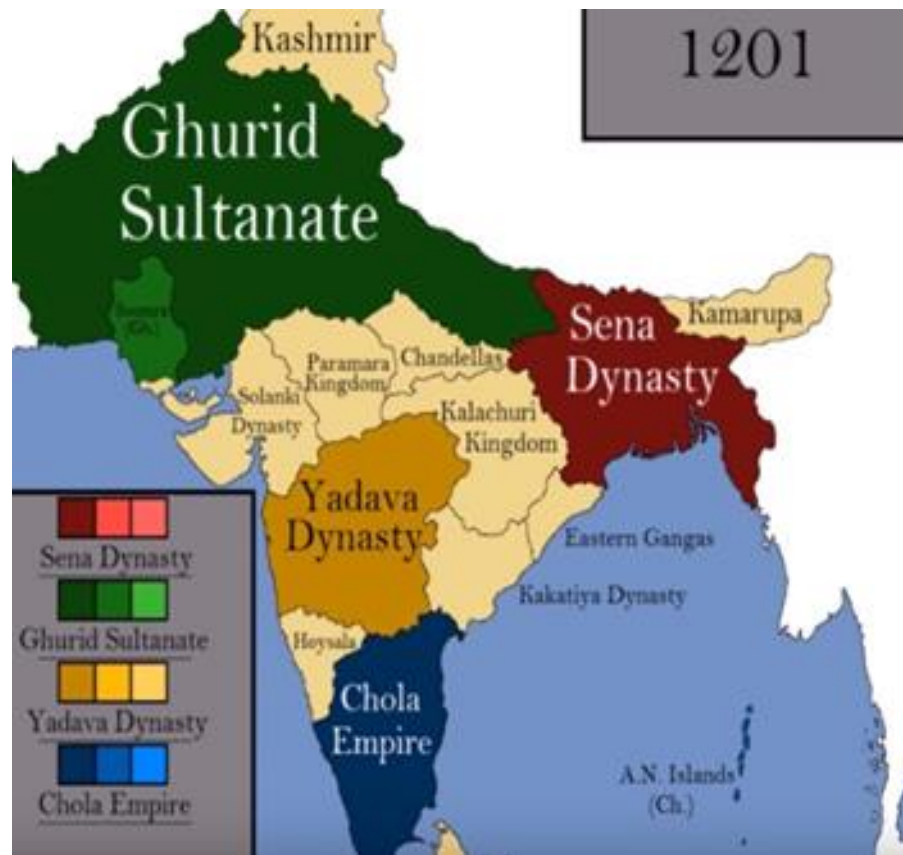
Shalban Mahavihara established by Bhavadeva in 8th century











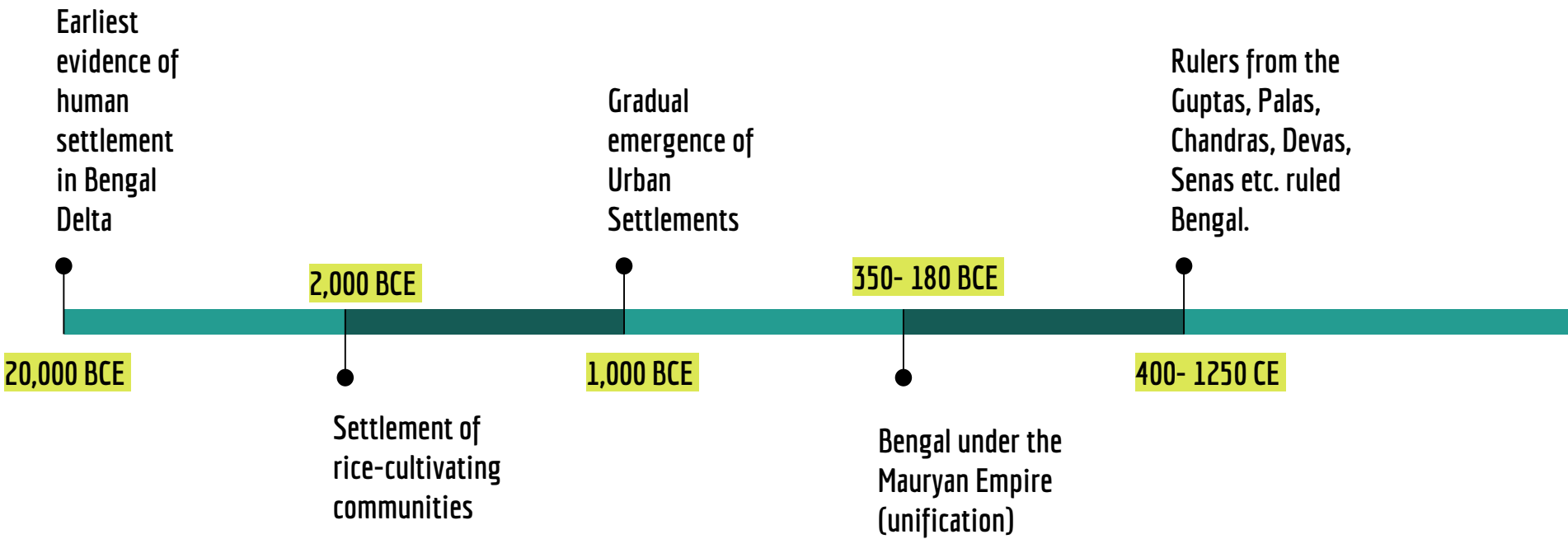
“... in this complex world of multiple and transforming religious identities a new creed, Islam, entered in two separate waves. In first, reached coastal bangladesh as a by-product of seaborne trade between the eighth and twelfth centuries”. Secondly, “in the early thirteenth century Islam also reached Bangladesh by land route, this time as the religion of powerful invaders.”

Why did the invaders come to the Indian Subcontinent?



# Why did the invaders come to the Indian Subcontinent?

- ❖ Rich with natural resources and wealth
  - ❖ Fertile land and supply of water
  - ❖ A major trading & commerce hub/region
  - ❖ Powerful empires and kingdoms that foreign powers sought to conquer and subjugate
- 
- ❖ Ibn BatTuta (in 1345) wrote about arriving in the country of Bengala:
    - ❖ “... which is a vast region abounding in rice after 43 days of sea journey. I have seen no country in the world where provisions are cheaper than in this country. But it is muggy and those who come from Khorasan, call it **a hell full of good things.**”



# Suggested Readings

## **Required Reading:**

**Salahuddin, A. F. (Ed.) (2004). *Bangladesh National Culture and Heritage*. Dhaka: IUB. Pages: 53-65**

## Recommended Readings:

Sengupta, N. (2011). *Land of Two Rivers*. India: Penguin Books

Rahim, M. A., Choudhury, A. M., Mahmud, A. B. M. & Islam, S. (2005). *Bangladesher Etihash (History of Bangladesh)*. Dhaka: Nouruj Kitabistan.



# Next Class Preview

**From Origins of Bengal Sultanates to  
the Battle of Polashi (1204-1757):  
Society, Religion and Politics**